

Jeremiah 7 - 9

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight Jeremiah is sent to preach at the one address where no one expects a rebuke - the gate of the temple itself, to people on their way in to worship.

A building treated as a charm, chanted three times over.

A ruin at Shiloh that nobody wanted to go look at.

A prophet who wishes his head were water so he could weep without stopping.

Jeremiah 7 is the temple sermon: stand where they enter, and tell them the address does not save them. Amend your ways. Do justice at the gate. And go see what happened to the last place I put My name.

Jeremiah 8 watches a people who will not turn - who know less about Yahweh's seasons than migrating birds know about their own - and ends with the question that has haunted every honest reader since: is there no balm in Gilead?

Jeremiah 9 is the weeping. Not restrained, not tidy - a call for professional mourners because the grief has outrun the ordinary means of expressing it. And in the middle of it, the verse that resets everything worth boasting about.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 7 - The Temple Sermon and the Valley of Slaughter

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is stationed at the gate of Yahweh's house and told to preach to worshippers as they enter - the most confrontational possible pulpit (Jeremiah 7:1-2).
- The offer is conditional and concrete: amend your ways and your doings, and I will cause you to dwell in this place (Jeremiah 7:3).
- The threefold chant - Yahweh's temple, Yahweh's temple, Yahweh's temple - is named as lying words. Repetition had turned a promise into a superstition (Jeremiah 7:4, 8).
- What amending actually means is spelled out in social terms: justice between neighbors, no oppression of the foreigner, the fatherless, or the widow, no innocent blood, no other gods (Jeremiah 7:5-7).
- The devastating sequence of verses 9-10: break the commandments in the street, then stand in the house called by His name and announce "we are delivered" - as though the building laundered the conduct.
- "A den of robbers" is not a charge of commerce but of refuge - a cave where criminals feel safe between jobs. It is the line Yahshua will quote when He clears the courts (Jeremiah 7:11).
- Go to Shiloh and look. Yahweh had put His name there first, and the ruins were still visible. Election of a place has never been a guarantee against judgment on it (Jeremiah 7:12-15).
- The second prohibition on intercession: do not pray for this people, for I will not hear you (Jeremiah 7:16).
- Family idolatry described as a household craft - children gathering wood, fathers kindling, women kneading cakes for the queen of the sky. Everyone has a job (Jeremiah 7:17-20).
- The sacrificial system is put in its place: what Yahweh commanded at the exodus was not burnt offerings first but "listen to my voice" (Jeremiah 7:21-26).
- Topheth in the valley of Hinnom - child sacrifice Yahweh says never entered His mind - will be renamed the Valley of Slaughter (Jeremiah 7:30-34).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Temple as Talisman	Jeremiah 7:4 • Micah 3:11 • Jeremiah 7:8
Justice at the Gate as True Worship	Jeremiah 7:5-7 • Isaiah 1:17 • Zechariah 7:9-10
A Den of Robbers	Jeremiah 7:11 • Matthew 21:13 • Mark 11:17
Remember What Happened at Shiloh	Jeremiah 7:12 • 1 Samuel 4:10-11 • Psalm 78:60
"Don't Pray for This People"	Jeremiah 7:16 • Jeremiah 11:14 • Jeremiah 14:11
Cakes for the Queen of the Sky	Jeremiah 7:18 • Jeremiah 44:17 • Deuteronomy 4:19

Topic	References
Obedience Before Sacrifice	Jeremiah 7:22-23 • 1 Samuel 15:22 • Hosea 6:6
Topheth and the Valley of Hinnom	Jeremiah 7:31 • Leviticus 18:21 • 2 Kings 23:10

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The House Cleared by Its Owner	Jeremiah 7:11 • Matthew 21:13 • Mark 11:17
The Temple That Would Be Raised in Three Days	Jeremiah 7:14 • John 2:19-21 • Hebrews 9:11
A People Who Become the Dwelling Place	Jeremiah 7:4 • 1 Corinthians 3:16 • Ephesians 2:21-22
Mercy Desired More Than Sacrifice	Jeremiah 7:22-23 • Hosea 6:6 • Matthew 9:13
The Intercessor Who Is Always Heard	Jeremiah 7:16 • Hebrews 7:25 • Romans 8:34
Gehenna - the Valley That Named the Judgment	Jeremiah 7:32 • Matthew 10:28 • Mark 9:43

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 7 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the temple sermon, the Shiloh precedent, and the Topheth oracle
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 7](#) - Torah-honoring treatment of obedience versus sacrifice in verses 21-23
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 7](#) - background on Shiloh's destruction and the queen-of-heaven cult

Jeremiah 7 - Opening Intro

Imagine being posted at the door of your own congregation on a feast day, told to say this to people as they arrive with their offerings. That is the assignment.

And the message is not that the temple is worthless. Yahweh built it. He put His name in it. The message is that they have started treating it the way people treat a lucky object - saying the words three times and assuming the words do the work.

So He sends them on a field trip. Go to Shiloh. That is where the tabernacle stood for centuries, where Hannah prayed and Samuel heard his name in the night. Go stand in what is left of it. Yahweh's name having been in a place is not the same as Yahweh being obligated to that place.

Then verses 5 through 7 tell us what would actually have changed the outcome, and it is striking how little of it is religious in the narrow sense. Deal justly with your neighbor. Do not squeeze the immigrant, the orphan, the widow. Do not shed innocent blood.

Before we read, sit with the hard question this chapter asks: whether the things that make us feel secure before God are things He actually asked of us.

Jeremiah 7:1-34 (WEB)

- 1 The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying,
- 2 “Stand in the gate of Yahweh’s house, and proclaim this word there, and say, ‘Hear Yahweh’s word, all you of Judah, who enter in at these gates to worship Yahweh.’”
- 3 Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel says, “Amend your ways and your doings, and I will cause you to dwell in this place.
- 4 Don’t trust in lying words, saying, ‘Yahweh’s temple, Yahweh’s temple, Yahweh’s temple, are these.’¹
- 5 For if you thoroughly amend your ways and your doings, if you thoroughly execute justice between a man and his neighbor;
- 6 if you don’t oppress the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow, and don’t shed innocent blood in this place, and don’t walk after other gods to your own hurt;
- 7 then I will cause you to dwell in this place, in the land that I gave to your fathers, from of old even forever more.
- 8 Behold, you trust in lying words that can’t profit.
- 9 Will you steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely, burn incense to Baal, and walk after other gods that you have not known,
- 10 then come and stand before me in this house, which is called by my name, and say, ‘We are delivered;’ that you may do all these abominations?
- 11 Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes? Behold, I myself have seen it,” says Yahweh.^{2,3}
- 12 “But go now to my place which was in Shiloh, where I caused my name to dwell at the first, and see what I did to it for the wickedness of my people Israel.⁴

¹ Cross-Reference: [Micah 3:11](#) - leaning on Yahweh’s presence as insurance while selling justice for bribes

² Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 7:12](#) • [Psalm 78:60](#) - the house called by His name, and the sanctuary He had already abandoned once

³ Messianic Connection: [Matthew 21:13](#) - Yahshua quoting this verse as He drives out those who had made the courts a refuge for robbery

⁴ Cross-Reference: [1 Samuel 4:10-11](#) - Shiloh’s ruin - the ark taken and Eli’s sons killed, with the sanctuary left desolate

13 Now, because you have done all these works,” says Yahweh, “and I spoke to you, rising up early and speaking, but you didn’t hear; and I called you, but you didn’t answer;

14 therefore I will do to the house which is called by my name, in which you trust, and to the place which I gave to you and to your fathers, as I did to Shiloh.⁵

15 I will cast you out of my sight, as I have cast out all your brothers, even the whole offspring of Ephraim.

16 “Therefore don’t pray for this people. Don’t lift up a cry or prayer for them or make intercession to me; for I will not hear you.^{6,7}

17 Don’t you see what they do in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem?

18 The children gather wood, and the fathers kindle the fire, and the women knead the dough, to make cakes to the queen of the sky, and to pour out drink offerings to other gods, that they may provoke me to anger.⁸

19 Do they provoke me to anger?” says Yahweh. “Don’t they provoke themselves, to the confusion of their own faces?”

20 Therefore thus says the Lord Yahweh: “Behold, my anger and my wrath will be poured out on this place, on man, on animal, on the trees of the field, and on the fruit of the ground; and it will burn and will not be quenched.”

21 Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel says: “Add your burnt offerings to your sacrifices and eat meat.

22 For I didn’t speak to your fathers or command them in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt concerning burnt offerings or sacrifices;

23 but this thing I commanded them, saying, ‘Listen to my voice, and I will be your God, and you shall be my people; and walk in all the way that I command you, that it may be well with you.’⁹

24 But they didn’t listen or turn their ear, but walked in their own counsels and in the stubbornness of their evil heart, and went backward, and not forward.

25 Since the day that your fathers came out of the land of Egypt to this day, I have sent to you all my servants the prophets, daily rising up early and sending them.

26 Yet they didn’t listen to me or incline their ear, but made their neck stiff. They did worse than their fathers.

⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [John 2:19-21](#) - the temple He spoke of was His body, raised in three days when the stone one fell

⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 11:14](#) - the same prohibition repeated - intercession that Yahweh will not receive

⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 7:25](#) - the Intercessor who always lives to make intercession, and is always heard

⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 44:17](#) - the same cult defended by the survivors in Egypt, who credited it with their prosperity

⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [1 Samuel 15:22](#) • [Hosea 6:6](#) - obedience better than sacrifice; mercy desired more than burnt offerings

27 “You shall speak all these words to them, but they will not listen to you. You shall also call to them, but they will not answer you.

28 You shall tell them, ‘This is the nation that has not listened to Yahweh their God’s voice, nor received instruction. Truth has perished, and is cut off from their mouth.’

29 Cut off your hair, and throw it away, and take up a lamentation on the bare heights; for Yahweh has rejected and forsaken the generation of his wrath.

30 “For the children of Judah have done that which is evil in my sight,” says Yahweh. “They have set their abominations in the house which is called by my name, to defile it.

31 They have built the high places of Topheth, which is in the valley of the son of Hinnom, to burn their sons and their daughters in the fire; which I didn’t command, nor did it come into my mind.¹⁰

32 Therefore behold, the days come”, says Yahweh, “that it will no more be called ‘Topheth’ or ‘The valley of the son of Hinnom’, but ‘The valley of Slaughter’; for they will bury in Topheth until there is no place to bury.

33 The dead bodies of this people will be food for the birds of the sky, and for the animals of the earth. No one will frighten them away.

34 Then I will cause to cease from the cities of Judah, and from the streets of Jerusalem, the voice of mirth and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride; for the land will become a waste.”

¹⁰ Cross-Reference: [Leviticus 18:21](#) • [2 Kings 23:10](#) - the explicit Torah prohibition, and Josiah’s defiling of Topheth to stop it

CHAPTER 8 - The Stork Knows Her Seasons, and No Balm in Gilead

Key Notes

- The bones of kings, priests, and prophets will be exhumed and spread before the sun, moon, and host of heaven they worshipped - the gods they served given their remains (Jeremiah 8:1-3).
- Two questions expose the unnaturalness of the situation: do men fall and not get up? Does one turn away and not return? Backsliding has become perpetual, a permanent condition rather than an episode (Jeremiah 8:4-5).
- Nobody says the four words that would change everything: "What have I done?" Instead each rushes on his course like a warhorse charging into battle (Jeremiah 8:6).
- The stork, turtledove, swallow, and crane all keep their appointed times. Migratory birds are more attentive to Yahweh's calendar than the people who received His Torah (Jeremiah 8:7).
- A claim to wisdom is met with a charge against the scribes: the pen that should have preserved Torah has worked falsely (Jeremiah 8:8-9).
- The indictment from chapter 6 returns nearly word for word - covetousness from least to greatest, "peace, peace" where there is none, and a people who have lost the capacity to blush (Jeremiah 8:10-12).
- "The harvest is past. The summer has ended, and we are not saved." A season that had a limit, and was allowed to close (Jeremiah 8:20).
- Jeremiah's identification with the wound is total: for the hurt of my people, I am hurt (Jeremiah 8:21).
- The chapter closes with three questions and no answer. Gilead was famous for balm; physicians existed. The medicine was not lacking - the patient refused it (Jeremiah 8:22).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Worshippers Given to Their Idols	Jeremiah 8:2 • Deuteronomy 4:19 • 2 Kings 23:5
Nobody Says "What Have I Done?"	Jeremiah 8:6 • Jeremiah 2:35 • Psalm 139:23-24
Birds Know Their Seasons	Jeremiah 8:7 • Isaiah 1:3 • Luke 12:56
The False Pen of the Scribes	Jeremiah 8:8 • Matthew 15:6 • Mark 7:13
"Peace, Peace," When There Is No Peace	Jeremiah 8:11 • Jeremiah 6:14 • Ezekiel 13:10
Losing the Capacity to Blush	Jeremiah 8:12 • Zephaniah 3:5 • Philippians 3:19
The Harvest Past, the Summer Ended	Jeremiah 8:20 • Matthew 25:11-12 • 2 Corinthians 6:2
Balm in Gilead	Jeremiah 8:22 • Genesis 37:25 • Jeremiah 46:11

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Physician Who Came to the Sick	Jeremiah 8:22 • Matthew 9:12 • Mark 2:17
Healing in His Wings	Jeremiah 8:22 • Malachi 4:2 • Isaiah 53:5
Reading the Season and Missing the Hour	Jeremiah 8:7 • Luke 12:56 • Luke 19:44
Now Is the Day of Salvation	Jeremiah 8:20 • 2 Corinthians 6:2 • Hebrews 3:15
The Door That Closes	Jeremiah 8:20 • Matthew 25:11-12 • Luke 13:25
Tradition That Nullifies the Word	Jeremiah 8:8 • Mark 7:13 • Matthew 15:6

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 8 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the perpetual backsliding, the scribes' false pen, and the closing lament over Gilead
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 8](#) - reading of the appointed-times imagery and the failure to discern the season
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 8](#) - exposition of verses 20-22 and the historical balm trade of Gilead

Jeremiah 8 - Opening Intro

Verse 7 is one of the quietest rebukes in the prophets, and one of the sharpest. A stork does not consult a calendar. It simply knows. So does the turtledove, the swallow, the crane. They keep appointments they were never taught.

And Judah, who was taught - who had the feasts written down, the sabbaths marked, the whole rhythm of Yahweh's year handed to them in writing - does not know.

Then verse 20, which may be the saddest sentence in the book. Harvest past. Summer ended. And we are not saved. It is the voice of people realizing that a window they assumed would stay open had a closing date all along, and that they had been busy during it.

And finally the three questions of verse 22, which are not really questions. Gilead had balm - it was the region's famous export, carried by the caravan that bought Joseph. There were physicians. The supply was never the problem.

Before we read, hold this honestly: the ache in that last verse is not that healing was unavailable. It is that it was right there, and went unused.

Jeremiah 8:1-22 (WEB)

1 “At that time,” says Yahweh, “they will bring out the bones of the kings of Judah, the bones of his princes, the bones of the priests, the bones of the prophets, and the bones of the inhabitants of Jerusalem, out of their graves.

2 They will spread them before the sun, the moon, and all the army of the sky, which they have loved, which they have served, after which they have walked, which they have sought, and which they have worshiped. They will not be gathered or be buried. They will be for dung on the surface of the earth.

3 Death will be chosen rather than life by all the residue that remain of this evil family, that remain in all the places where I have driven them,” says Yahweh of Armies.

4 “Moreover you shall tell them, ‘Yahweh says: “Do men fall, and not rise up again? Does one turn away, and not return?

5 Why then have the people of Jerusalem fallen back by a perpetual backsliding? They cling to deceit. They refuse to return.

6 I listened and heard, but they didn’t say what is right. No one repents of his wickedness, saying, “What have I done?” Everyone turns to his course, as a horse that rushes headlong in the battle.¹¹

7 Yes, the stork in the sky knows her appointed times. The turtledove, the swallow, and the crane observe the time of their coming; but my people don’t know Yahweh’s law.¹²⁻¹³

8 “How do you say, “We are wise, and Yahweh’s law is with us?” But, behold, the false pen of the scribes has worked falsely.¹⁴

9 The wise men are disappointed. They are dismayed and trapped. Behold, they have rejected Yahweh’s word. What kind of wisdom is in them?

10 Therefore will I give their wives to others, and their fields to those who will possess them. For everyone from the least even to the greatest is given to covetousness; from the prophet even to the priest everyone deals falsely.

11 They have healed the hurt of the daughter of my people slightly, saying, “Peace, peace,” when there is no peace.¹⁵

12 Were they ashamed when they had committed abomination? No, they were not at all ashamed. They couldn’t blush. Therefore they will fall among those who fall. In the time of their visitation they will be cast down, says Yahweh.

¹¹ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 2:35](#) - the same refusal to name the sin - “I have not sinned” as the settled posture

¹² Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 1:3](#) - the ox and the donkey knowing their owner, while Israel does not consider

¹³ Messianic Connection: [Luke 12:56](#) - able to read the sky and unable to read the hour they were living in

¹⁴ Messianic Connection: [Mark 7:13](#) - tradition handed down that nullifies the very word it claims to preserve

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 6:14](#) • [Ezekiel 13:10](#) - the identical charge of false peace, and the whitewash over a failing wall

13 “I will utterly consume them, says Yahweh. No grapes will be on the vine, no figs on the fig tree, and the leaf will fade. The things that I have given them will pass away from them.”

14 “Why do we sit still? Assemble yourselves, and let us enter into the fortified cities, and let us be silent there; for Yahweh our God has put us to silence, and given us water of gall to drink, because we have sinned against Yahweh.

15 We looked for peace, but no good came; and for a time of healing, and behold, dismay!

16 The snorting of his horses is heard from Dan. The whole land trembles at the sound of the neighing of his strong ones; for they have come, and have devoured the land and all that is in it; the city and those who dwell therein.”

17 “For, behold, I will send serpents, adders among you, which will not be charmed; and they will bite you,” says Yahweh.

18 Oh that I could comfort myself against sorrow! My heart is faint within me.

19 Behold, the voice of the cry of the daughter of my people from a land that is very far off: “Isn’t Yahweh in Zion? Isn’t her King in her?” “Why have they provoked me to anger with their engraved images, and with foreign idols?”

20 “The harvest is past. The summer has ended, and we are not saved.” ^{16,17}

21 For the hurt of the daughter of my people, I am hurt. I mourn. Dismay has taken hold of me.

22 Is there no balm in Gilead? Is there no physician there? Why then isn’t the health of the daughter of my people recovered? ^{18,19}

¹⁶ Cross-Reference: [2 Corinthians 6:2](#) - now is the acceptable time; now is the day of salvation

¹⁷ Messianic Connection: [Matthew 25:11-12](#) - the door shut, and the answer from inside - I do not know you

¹⁸ Cross-Reference: [Genesis 37:25](#) - balm among the goods of the Gilead caravan - the remedy was a known export

¹⁹ Messianic Connection: [Malachi 4:2](#) - the sun of righteousness rising with healing in its wings for those who fear His name

CHAPTER 9 - A Fountain of Tears and the Only Boast Worth Having

Key Notes

- The chapter opens with a wish rather than an oracle: that his head were waters and his eyes a spring of tears, so the weeping could match the loss (Jeremiah 9:1).
- His second wish is escape - a traveller's lodge in the wilderness, anywhere but among them. Faithfulness and the desire to leave are not mutually exclusive (Jeremiah 9:2).
- The central sin of this chapter is speech. Tongues bent like bows, aimed and drawn, trained to lie until lying takes effort - "they weary themselves committing iniquity" (Jeremiah 9:3-5).
- Social trust has collapsed to the point that Yahweh warns them against their own brothers and neighbors. Deceit is the habitation they live inside (Jeremiah 9:4-6).
- The link between deceit and ignorance of God is made explicit twice: through deceit, they refuse to know me. Lying is not merely a symptom; it is how they keep from knowing Him (Jeremiah 9:3, 6).
- The tongue is a drawn arrow: peaceable words in the mouth while the heart prepares an ambush (Jeremiah 9:8).
- Professional mourning women are summoned because the grief has exceeded amateur capacity, and mothers are told to teach their daughters lamentation - a generation raised in grief (Jeremiah 9:17-21).
- The great reversal of verses 23-24: not wisdom, not might, not riches. The only boast permitted is understanding and knowing Yahweh - and what one knows about Him is that He delights in loving kindness, justice, and righteousness in the earth (Jeremiah 9:23-24).
- The chapter ends by collapsing the distinction the people relied on most: circumcised in flesh, uncircumcised in heart, listed alongside Egypt, Edom, Ammon, and Moab (Jeremiah 9:25-26).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
A Fountain of Tears	Jeremiah 9:1 • Lamentations 3:48-49 • Psalm 119:136
The Tongue Bent Like a Bow	Jeremiah 9:3 • Psalm 64:3 • Psalm 11:2
Trust No Brother	Jeremiah 9:4 • Micah 7:5-6 • Psalm 55:12-14
Wearying Themselves in Iniquity	Jeremiah 9:5 • Isaiah 57:10 • Proverbs 4:16
Peaceable Words, an Ambushing Heart	Jeremiah 9:8 • Psalm 55:21 • Proverbs 26:24-25
Called for the Mourning Women	Jeremiah 9:17 • Amos 5:16 • Ecclesiastes 12:5
The Only Boast Permitted	Jeremiah 9:23-24 • 1 Corinthians 1:31 • 2 Corinthians 10:17
Circumcised in Flesh, Uncircumcised in Heart	Jeremiah 9:25-26 • Romans 2:28-29 • Acts 7:51

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Prophet Who Wept Over the City	Jeremiah 9:1 • Luke 19:41-44 • John 11:35
The Untamable Tongue	Jeremiah 9:3 • James 3:5-8 • Matthew 12:36-37
Boasting Only in the Lord	Jeremiah 9:24 • 1 Corinthians 1:31 • Galatians 6:14
Knowing Him as Eternal Life	Jeremiah 9:24 • John 17:3 • Philippians 3:8
Loving Kindness, Justice, and Righteousness	Jeremiah 9:24 • Micah 6:8 • Matthew 23:23
Circumcision of the Heart	Jeremiah 9:26 • Romans 2:28-29 • Colossians 2:11

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 9 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the lament, the sins of the tongue, and the boasting passage of verses 23-24
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 9](#) - covenant reading of the heart-circumcision charge that closes the chapter
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 9](#) - notes on the mourning-women custom and the structure of the lament

Jeremiah 9 - Opening Intro

This is where the title “the weeping prophet” comes from, and it is worth noticing that Jeremiah does not present his tears as a strength. He presents them as insufficient. He wants more water than he has.

It is also worth noticing his second wish, in verse 2. He wants out. A lodge in the desert, away from all of them. The man who will not stop delivering the message would very much like to stop living among the people he delivers it to. Faithfulness does not require pretending you enjoy it.

The sin under the microscope here is speech - and the diagnosis is precise. They have taught their tongue to speak lies. Taught. It took practice. And they weary themselves at it, which means deceit has become laborious, a full-time occupation requiring maintenance.

And then, out of the middle of all that grief, comes verses 23 and 24 - one of the great summary statements of scripture. Three things people build their lives on, all disqualified. One thing left: knowing Him. And what you find when you know Him is not raw power but loving kindness, justice, and righteousness - and that He delights in them.

Before we read, carry this: the chapter that weeps hardest is also the chapter that tells us most plainly what God is actually like.

Jeremiah 9:1-26 (WEB)

1 Oh that my head were waters, and my eyes a spring of tears, that I might weep day and night for the slain of the daughter of my people!^{20,21}

2 Oh that I had in the wilderness a lodging place of wayfaring men; that I might leave my people, and go from them! For they are all adulterers, an assembly of treacherous men.

3 “They bend their tongue, as their bow, for falsehood. They have grown strong in the land, but not for truth; for they proceed from evil to evil, and they don’t know me,” says Yahweh.^{22,23}

4 “Everyone beware of his neighbor, and don’t trust in any brother; for every brother will utterly supplant, and every neighbor will go around with slanders.

5 Everyone will deceive their neighbors, and will not speak the truth. They have taught their tongue to speak lies. They weary themselves committing iniquity.

6 Your habitation is in the middle of deceit. Through deceit, they refuse to know me,” says Yahweh.

7 Therefore Yahweh of Armies says, “Behold, I will melt them and test them; for how should I deal with the daughter of my people?

8 Their tongue is a deadly arrow. It speaks deceit. One speaks peaceably to his neighbor with his mouth, but in his heart, he waits to ambush him.²⁴

9 Shouldn’t I punish them for these things?” says Yahweh. “Shouldn’t my soul be avenged on a nation such as this?

10 I will weep and wail for the mountains, and lament for the pastures of the wilderness, because they are burned up, so that no one passes through; Men can’t hear the voice of the livestock. Both the birds of the sky and the animals have fled. They are gone.

11 “I will make Jerusalem heaps, a dwelling place of jackals. I will make the cities of Judah a desolation, without inhabitant.”

12 Who is wise enough to understand this? Who is he to whom the mouth of Yahweh has spoken, that he may declare it? Why has the land perished and burned up like a wilderness, so that no one passes through?

13 Yahweh says, “Because they have forsaken my law which I set before them, and have not obeyed my voice, neither walked therein,

²⁰ Cross-Reference: [Lamentations 3:48-49](#) - the same prophet’s eyes running down without intermission for his people

²¹ Messianic Connection: [Luke 19:41-44](#) - the One who came near, saw the city, and wept over what it had missed

²² Cross-Reference: [Psalm 64:3](#) - tongues sharpened like swords and words aimed like arrows

²³ Messianic Connection: [James 3:5-8](#) - a small member set on fire, which no one is able to tame

²⁴ Cross-Reference: [Psalm 55:21](#) - words smoother than butter while war is in the heart

14 but have walked after the stubbornness of their own heart, and after the Baals, which their fathers taught them.”

15 Therefore Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says, “Behold, I will feed them, even this people, with wormwood, and give them water of gall to drink.

16 I will scatter them also among the nations, whom neither they nor their fathers have known; and I will send the sword after them, until I have consumed them.”

17 Yahweh of Armies says, “Consider, and call for the mourning women, that they may come; and send for the skillful women, that they may come.”²⁵

18 Let them make haste, and take up a wailing for us, that our eyes may run down with tears, and our eyelids gush out with waters.

19 For a voice of wailing is heard out of Zion, ‘How we are ruined! We are greatly confounded, because we have forsaken the land, because they have cast down our dwellings.’”

20 Yet hear Yahweh’s word, you women. Let your ear receive the word of his mouth. Teach your daughters wailing, and everyone her neighbor lamentation.

21 For death has come up into our windows. It has entered into our palaces to cut off the children from outside, and the young men from the streets.

22 Speak, “Yahweh says, “‘The dead bodies of men will fall as dung on the open field, and as the handful after the harvester; and no one will gather them.’”

23 Yahweh says, “Don’t let the wise man glory in his wisdom. Don’t let the mighty man glory in his might. Don’t let the rich man glory in his riches.

24 But let him who glories glory in this, that he has understanding, and knows me, that I am Yahweh who exercises loving kindness, justice, and righteousness, in the earth; for I delight in these things,” says Yahweh.^{26,27}

25 “Behold, the days come,” says Yahweh, “that I will punish all those who are circumcised only in their flesh:

26 Egypt, Judah, Edom, the children of Ammon, Moab, and all who have the corners of their hair cut off, who dwell in the wilderness; for all the nations are uncircumcised, and all the house of Israel are uncircumcised in heart.”^{28,29}

²⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Amos 5:16](#) - professional mourners called into the streets when grief outruns ordinary lament

²⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Micah 6:6-8](#) - what Yahweh actually requires - justice, mercy, and walking humbly with Him

²⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [1 Corinthians 1:31](#) - the apostolic echo - let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord

²⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Acts 7:51](#) - uncircumcised in heart and ears, resisting the Spirit as the fathers did

²⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [Romans 2:28-29](#) - the circumcision that counts is of the heart, by the Spirit, praised by God and not men

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 7-9

- A holy place treated as a charm - the address mistaken for the relationship
- Shiloh as the standing proof that Yahweh's name on a site is no guarantee for the site
- Worship measured at the gate: the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow as the actual test
- Obedience commanded before sacrifice, at the exodus and ever since
- Migratory birds keeping appointed times that a Torah-holding people no longer recognize
- A season with a closing date - harvest past, summer ended, and the window shut
- Balm available and physicians present, with the wound left untreated by choice
- Speech as the engine of estrangement - tongues trained to lie until deceit becomes hard work
- Grief so large it requires professional mourners and has to be taught to the next generation
- Wisdom, might, and riches disqualified as boasts; knowing Yahweh left standing alone
- Circumcision of the flesh without circumcision of the heart, counted with the nations

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who sent His prophet to the gate give us the courage to hear correction in the places where we feel most secure, and may we never mistake the building for the covenant.

May He make our worship legible at the gate - in how we treat the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow - so that what we sing inside is confirmed by what we do outside.

May He teach us to say the four words this generation would not say: what have I done? And may He meet that question with mercy, as He always has.

May we know the season we are in, as surely as the stork knows hers, and may we not let the harvest pass while we are busy with lesser things.

May He heal what we have left untreated, and may we stop refusing the balm that has been within reach the whole time.

May He tame the tongue no one can tame, and make our speech a place where our neighbors are safe.

And may we boast in nothing but this - that we know Him, who delights in loving kindness, justice, and righteousness in the earth.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.